daughters – Aqsa, Ajwa, Asmara and Ansha. Truth be told, with the birth of each, my luck kept on improving. Daughters are a blessing. They really are.

Aqsa is in the 10th grade, Ansha is in the ninth. They're both great at sports and even better in academics. Ansha wants to help out with the Shahid Afridi Foundation after she completes her studies. Ajwa and Asmara are the youngest and love to play dress-up. They have my permission to play any sport, as long as they're indoors. Cricket? No, not for my girls. They have permission to play all the indoor games they want, but my daughters are not going to be competing in public sporting activities. It's for social and religious reasons that I've made this decision and their mother agrees with me. The feminists can say what they want; as a conservative Pakistani father, I've made my decision.

I've always given religion a place in my heart. It started with my family. I started praying very early in life. I found solace in it. Today, it is an important part of my parenting regime as well. It doesn't matter what sort of day I've had. When I pray, everything makes sense. Everything. Whenever I miss my morning prayers, I have a terribly stressful day. The day I hit all my targets must include my praying five times a day.

I try to keep the family together. My sisters. My brothers. My cousins. Whenever I'm in Karachi, I try to have them over once a week. They all come over and get together and I do what I can to help them out and fix their problems. And then we eat. Together.

I've been lucky. I haven't seen abject poverty. We got close to it, sure, but we had a smart father who always set things right when they got rough. Before we moved to Karachi from Khyber, my father made sure we had a proper place for us to live, with a secure roof over our heads.

Soon after we all arrived in Karachi, my father had enough to make us a little house. We weren't terribly rich, though. But we were fortunate and there was *barkat*, blessings and goodwill, in what we earned. We had a modest income. We lived within our means. We had enough to last the month but not beyond that. It wasn't much but it was good enough. Of course, it wasn't easy. Not by any means. I think that lifestyle gave me a can-do ethic, which is hinged on my belief that things eventually work out. Self-belief is key, but things indeed tend to work themselves out. Yes, there were setbacks along the way. But we overcame them.

Of course, I have fears. I have sinned. Who hasn't? But if you've done good deeds, you don't even fear death. But you know what really scares me? The world that awaits the younger generation. My kids. Your kids. The unregulated exposure of the internet, with our kids in the mix. That is what scares me.

Different people have different fears. For example, I've read, heard and even seen that Imran Khan is scared to fail. It's a reason for his success. He can't handle failure. But for me, failure is an opportunity. You can always bounce back. You can trip, you can fall, but you have to get back on your feet again. You cannot, ever, give up. I've been kicked out of teams. I've been injured, I've been politically written off. I've even been picked at. But I haven't stopped.

Moreover, I don't care whether you're a believer or not and it doesn't matter if you're a Muslim or a Hindu or an atheist or whatever, hard work is always rewarded. If you believe in God, He does the rewarding. If you don't believe in Him – though you should – life rewards you. The universe rewards you. Good deeds bring good gains. That's what I think.

It's a funny thing, fortune. Some people have a lot of it in a good way, while others don't. I